

SYSTEMATIC SCOPING REVIEW

Mesopotamian Incantation Bowls

A chronological and thematic review of the scholarship, corpus, methods, and open questions

COVERAGE

1853 - July 2026

PRIMARY CORPORA

JBA, Mandaic, Syriac, Pahlavi, and pseudo-script bowls

METHOD

Full-corpus historical, philological, material, social, and provenance synthesis

RESEARCH EDITION

Contents

This reading edition preserves the review's evidence grades, live source links, selected bibliography, and research plan.

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Introduction: empire, objects, and a changing field

Incantation bowls are ordinary ceramic vessels transformed into ritual objects by spiral, concentric, radial, or otherwise arranged inscriptions and, often, drawings. Most belong to late antique Mesopotamia, especially the Sasanian and immediately post-Sasanian centuries. The best-supported central date range is approximately 500-700 CE, with the densest evidence in the sixth and seventh centuries, rather than the very broad third-eighth-century range sometimes repeated in popular accounts. A small group carries absolute dates in the sixth and early seventh centuries, and excavated contexts allow some continuation into the early Islamic period. The principal languages and scripts are Jewish Babylonian Aramaic, Mandaic, and Syriac; Middle Persian in Pahlavi script and invented or pseudo-script bowls form related parts of the material field.

That chronology places the bowls inside one of the great political transformations of western Asia. The Sasanian dynasty ruled from 224 to 651 CE. Mesopotamia was not a remote fringe: its irrigated plains, cities, tax base, and the royal region around Ctesiphon made it a western heartland of the empire. The dynasty promoted an Iranian kingship closely associated with Zoroastrian institutions, but the population of Mesopotamia was religiously and linguistically plural. Jewish, Church of the East and other Christian, Mandaean, Manichaean, Zoroastrian, and locally rooted communities shared cities, markets, administrative structures, languages, stories, and ritual specialists without dissolving into a single culture. The bowls are products of this imperial society, not objects that merely happen to be dated by Sasanian rulers.

The main bowl horizon coincides with the empire's final long century. Under Khusrau I (531-579), centralizing reforms and renewed imperial power intensified the institutional world in which late antique Mesopotamians lived. Subsequent revolts and the prolonged Roman-Sasanian war of 602-628 destabilized the empire; succession struggles followed, Arab-Muslim armies took most of Iraq in the 630s and 640s, and the last Sasanian king died in 651. Bowl production did not halt on a single political date. Objects in early Islamic levels show continuity across regime change, while shifts in language, administration, settlement, and religious authority altered the environment in which the practice had flourished. The bowls therefore preserve household-scale evidence from the last Sasanian generations and the transition into early Islamic Mesopotamia. For the political frame, see the [Metropolitan Museum's historical overview](#); for the argument that Jewish life must be studied within, not merely against the background of, Sasanian imperial structures, see Simcha Gross's *Babylonian Jews and Sasanian Imperialism in Late Antiquity* ([Cambridge](#)).

The corpus is exceptionally important because it is domestic, named, and materially situated. Bowl texts frequently identify clients, family members, houses, adversaries, illnesses, reproductive dangers, demons, or other threats. They therefore illuminate forms of everyday religious action only obliquely represented in legal, theological, and literary texts. For late antique Babylonian Judaism in particular, the Jewish bowls are the only large surviving written corpus besides the Babylonian Talmud, or Bavli, from approximately the same region and broad period. The Bavli is a vast, layered rabbinic compilation of law, debate, interpretation, and narrative; it is not a transparent transcript of all Babylonian Jewish life. Reading bowls beside it places prescriptive and elite literary voices in conversation with personalized ritual

objects without assuming that one corpus was copied directly from the other. The importance of the comparison is emphasized by the editors of the 2025 field survey, *Aramaic Incantation Bowls in Their Late Antique Jewish Contexts* ([Brown Judaic Studies](#)).

The history of scholarship is itself part of the evidence. Thomas Ellis's 1853 decipherments made the bowls legible to European scholarship, while James A. Montgomery's 1913 Nippur edition created the first durable corpus and numbering system. Cyrus H. Gordon and other mid-century editors multiplied the available texts, sometimes faster than photographs, archaeological documentation, or dialect knowledge could support. Joseph Naveh and Shaul Shaked then showed how exact philology and formula comparison could correct inherited readings; Dan Levene, J. B. Segal, Christa Müller-Kessler, Marco Moriggi, James Nathan Ford, Matthew Morgenstern, Siam Bhayro, and their collaborators built the museum and language corpora on which comparison now depends.

At the same time, scholars changed the questions. Erica C. D. Hunter returned bowls to excavated houses and depositional contexts. Michael G. Morony made Sasanian society central rather than decorative background. Gideon Bohak and Yuval Harari¹ placed the bowls within longer histories of Jewish magic, while Jason Sion Mokhtarian, Avigail Manekin-Bamberger, Shai Secunda, and others recast the relationship with rabbinic culture as uneven participation in a shared Babylonian world. Naama Vilozy treated images as operative, not ornamental; Ortal-Paz Saar and Manekin-Bamberger separated client, beneficiary, textual voice, copyist, and author in gender analysis; Daniel James Waller made biblical quotation and written performativity auditable; and recent digital, multispectral, and provenance work has made the object, image, collection history, and data model as important as the edited text.

Across that history, three major interpretive shifts organize the present review:

1. **From curiosities to corpora.** Nineteenth-century decipherments and James A. Montgomery's 1913 Nippur edition established the objects as linguistic and religious evidence. Later museum catalogues and corpus editions made comparative work possible.
2. **From “popular magic” to heterogeneous scribal practice.** Earlier scholarship often opposed bowls to “normative” or rabbinic religion. Current research sees varied practitioners, clients, learned traditions, local formulae, and degrees of contact with rabbinic, liturgical, legal, biblical, Mandaean, Christian, Iranian, and older Mesopotamian materials. The corpus does not represent a single institution or social class.
3. **From text alone to object, household, network, and data.** Archaeology, materiality, images, handwriting, prosopography, gender, household history, provenance ethics, multispectral imaging, and digital ontology now stand beside philology. This has also weakened the assumption that script directly proves the religious identity of either client or practitioner.

The most durable conclusion is that there was no single “bowl religion” and probably no uniform ritual. The texts share technologies - binding, sealing, banning, divorcing, adjuring, invoking, narrating, quoting, drawing, and materially depositing - but recombine them in local and sometimes highly individual ways. Their efficacy could lie in language, divine or angelic authority, visual form, the permanence and placement of writing, the containment symbolism of the vessel, a spoken performance, or several of these at once.

¹ Yuval Harari, the scholar of Jewish magic and Jewish Thought and Folklore at Ben-Gurion University of the Negev, is a different person from Yuval Noah Harari, the historian and author of *Sapiens*.

The main obstacle to a fully systematic review is not lack of scholarship but an unstable evidence base. Several thousand bowls are reported or known, while only a fraction have reliable editions, photographs, secure find contexts, or uncontested provenance. Counts change as objects are published, reidentified, or linked across catalogues. Daniel James Waller counted more than 460 published JBA² bowls by November 2022 in *The Bible in the Bowls* ([open-access book](#)); the European Jewish Classical Magic project describes approximately 500 JBA magical objects, about 125 Mandaic bowls, and about 50 Syriac magical objects in its working corpora ([EJCM](#)³). Those figures are methodological working counts, not a census of all extant bowls. A full-scope review must therefore keep three levels distinct: the material corpus believed to exist, the published corpus that can be searched, and the smaller verified corpus for which image, edition, and provenance can be evaluated together.

1. Review method, scope, and limitations

This is a **systematic scoping review**, not a statistical meta-analysis and not a claim to have read every publication in full. Incantation-bowl scholarship is dispersed among monographs, museum catalogues, articles, excavation reports, dissertations, Festschriften, older publications in several languages, and unpublished collection records. Many primary texts have also been re-edited under different sigla.

1.1 Questions used to organize the review

- What objects constitute the corpus, and how securely can they be dated and located?
- How has the publication and interpretation of the corpus changed since 1853?
- What are the principal editions for each linguistic or script group?
- What do bowls contribute to the history of religion, language, ritual, households, gender, law, medicine, and textuality?
- Where do scholars genuinely disagree?
- Which evidence is sufficiently secure for historical or creative adaptation, and which remains provisional?
- What research procedure will keep the review current and make object-level claims auditable?

1.2 Sources included

Priority was given to:

- primary editions and museum catalogues;
- archaeological reports and museum collection descriptions;
- peer-reviewed linguistic, historical, religious-studies, and material-culture research;
- dissertations that introduced substantial corpora or methods;
- official digital projects and institutional repositories;

² Jewish Babylonian Aramaic, the principal Aramaic dialect and modern corpus label used for bowls written in Jewish square script.

³ European Jewish Classical Magic, a digital research project and structured corpus based at Ca' Foscari University of Venice.

- provenance research relevant to undocumented collections;
- the bibliographic state-of-the-field survey by Daniel James Waller, which lists JBA bowl publications from 1853 through 2024 in the 2025 edited volume ([JSTOR table of contents](#)).

The review treats the corpus as a whole from the outset. Individual objects, including CBS/B⁴ 2941 where it is bibliographically useful, appear as examples within the larger linguistic, material, and historiographical field rather than as the basis or destination of the review.

1.3 Search coverage

The review combined backward and forward citation chaining with searches for English, German, French, Italian, and Hebrew terms, including combinations of:

“incantation bowl,” “magic bowl,” “demon bowl,” Zauberschale, coupes magiques, coppe magique, קערות ההשבעה, Jewish Babylonian Aramaic, Mandaic, Syriac, Pahlavi, pseudo-script, Nippur, CBS, BM⁵, VA⁶, MS 2053, and individual object sigla.

Publisher records, JSTOR, Cambridge, Oxford, Brill, institutional repositories, museum pages, project sites, and open-access books were used to verify dates, titles, contents, and major claims. Coverage extends through scholarship published or publicly described by 13 July 2026.

Search strings, access level, and verification status are recorded separately from the prose review. This distinction matters because a publisher abstract can verify a title, date, or declared argument but cannot support line-level philology. Acronyms are defined in page footnotes at their first substantive use in the PDF reading editions; the same rule is applied selectively to institutional sigla when an expansion helps interpretation.

1.4 Evidence grades used here

- **A - secure object evidence:** published photograph or drawing plus a usable edition; excavated or documented collection history where available.
- **B - usable text evidence:** scholarly edition exists, but image, provenance, or full archaeological context is absent.
- **C - provisional:** abstract, catalogue notice, old hand copy, unverified reading, or unpublished object discussed without sufficient documentation.
- **D - unsuitable for historical inference:** modern adaptation, dealer description, decontextualized online image, or claim whose ancient source cannot be traced.

1.5 Limitations

- The full text of every paywalled work could not be inspected. Some 2025-2026 items are therefore represented at title-and-abstract level.
- Older German, French, and Hebrew scholarship is bibliographically represented more completely than it is analytically discussed.

⁴ Catalogue of the Babylonian Section / Babylonian Section: historic Penn Museum inventory prefixes used in bowl sigla.

⁵ British Museum, used here as an institutional and object-number prefix.

⁶ Vorderasiatisches Museum, the historic Berlin museum inventory prefix retained in bowl publications.

- Publication bias strongly favors legible JBA bowls and prominent collections.
- Objects from the antiquities market often lack archaeological context and may have duplicate or changing identifiers.
- “Jewish,” “Mandaean,” and “Christian” are not mechanically recoverable from script. They may describe language, graphic tradition, textual repertoire, producer, patron, or modern catalogue classification - and these need not coincide.

2. The corpus: what it is, where it comes from, and when it belongs

2.1 Physical form and deposition

Most bowls are inexpensive, wheel-made ceramic household vessels, often already suitable as everyday ware before inscription. Text normally proceeds in a spiral on the interior, but concentric, radial, exterior, rim, and mixed arrangements occur. Drawn figures, circles, grids, magical signs, seals, and pseudo-writing may be integral to the design.

Excavated examples were often deposited upside down beneath floors, at thresholds, in corners, or around the edges of domestic spaces; pairs were sometimes placed rim-to-rim. These patterns support interpretations involving protection, enclosure, immobilization, or control of harmful forces. They do **not** prove that every bowl was conceived as a literal demon trap. Depositional practice, text, image, and intended result vary.

Erica C. D. Hunter's reassessment of the Nippur discoveries remains essential because it returns the bowls to houses and strata rather than treating them only as manuscripts. The 1989 excavations recovered bowls in a stratified domestic context, and proximity between bowls in different Aramaic scripts complicates simple maps of separate religious neighborhoods. Hunter's article appears in the open *Nippur VII* volume ([SAOC⁷ 71 PDF](#)). Penn's current work likewise emphasizes that the institution holds a much larger and less selectively published Nippur assemblage than Montgomery edited - five displayed objects and roughly 285 in storage at the time of the report ([Penn Today](#)).

2.2 Geography

The heartland is central and southern Mesopotamia, especially sites in present-day Iraq. Nippur is crucial because of excavation, but the market corpus ranges across Iraq and western Iran, frequently without a reliable findspot. Khouabir, Borsippa/Birs Nimrud, Kutha, and other named locations appear in early reports; many such attributions require rechecking against excavation history.

The find distribution is therefore partly ancient and partly modern: excavation choices, colonial collecting, dealer networks, wars, museum acquisition, legibility, and scholarly access all shape the map. A bowl said to be “from Nippur” may mean excavated at Nippur, stylistically attributed to Nippur, acquired with other Nippur material, or merely assigned a dealer provenance. These categories must remain separate.

⁷ Studies in Ancient Oriental Civilization, an Oriental Institute publication series.

2.3 Sasanian Mesopotamia as the bowls' historical setting

The Sasanian Empire began when Ardashir I defeated the last Arsacid ruler in 224 CE and ended with the death of Yazdgard III in 651. Its political center moved across an imperial zone that joined the Iranian plateau to the Mesopotamian lowlands, but the royal capitals near Ctesiphon placed the great cities and agricultural districts of Iraq close to power. Imperial taxation, landholding, military movement, courts, legal traditions, roads, and markets shaped the same households in which bowls were commissioned and deposited.

Zoroastrianism had a privileged relationship to Sasanian kingship, and Zoroastrian priests and fire temples appear in contemporary Jewish and Christian texts. That privilege should not be simplified into a modern model of one uniformly enforced state religion. Sasanian Mesopotamia contained long-established Jewish populations, several Christian churches and monastic networks, Mandaean, Manichaean, Iranian religious communities, and adherents of other local traditions. Aramaic dialects remained widespread, while Middle Persian supplied imperial, administrative, legal, and onomastic vocabulary. Iranian personal names and supernatural beings in the bowls are therefore evidence of ordinary imperial entanglement, not necessarily the religious conversion of a client or scribe.

The political sequence helps interpret, but does not mechanically date, the objects. The sixth century included the long reign of Khusrau I (531-579), major administrative and fiscal change, urban and agricultural continuity, and recurrent war with the Roman Empire. The final war of 602-628 reached an extraordinary scale, after which dynastic instability and conquest transformed the regime. Muslim rule in Iraq was established during the 630s and 640s, before the Sasanian dynasty ended in 651. Bowls in early Islamic contexts show that ritual and scribal habits crossed this boundary. Consequently, "Sasanian bowl" is best used as a historical orientation, not as a claim that every object predates 651 or expresses official Iranian religion.

This history also changes how the scholarship is framed. Morony's social histories asked what named clients, Iranian names, work, kinship, and shared demonologies reveal about late Sasanian Iraq. More recently, Simcha Gross has argued that Babylonian Jewish institutions and texts were formed within Sasanian political conditions rather than in a self-contained Jewish sphere. Siam Bhayro's work on absolutely dated bowls and the 2025 field volume bring those imperial and chronological questions into object-level study. The result is a history in which bowls, the Bavli, Syriac literature, Mandaic sources, and Iranian evidence are separate archives of the same world, not isolated illustrations of predetermined communities.

2.4 Dating

The safest working range is **ca. 500-700 CE**, with the densest evidence in the sixth and seventh centuries. Dated bowls include specimens assigned to 545, 573/574, 580, 585, and 611 CE. Archaeological and palaeographic arguments may extend individual pieces earlier, while finds in early Islamic levels show that the practice did not end everywhere at the Sasanian collapse. The 2025 field volume explicitly frames the main Jewish corpus as late Sasanian to early Islamic ([Brown Judaic Studies](#)).

Dating remains uneven because:

- few bowls state a year;
- regnal, Seleucid, and local dating formulae require interpretation;
- many objects lack find context;

- palaeography is still not anchored by enough independently dated hands;
- formulae could circulate longer than a scribe or workshop;
- older publications sometimes date by broad religious-historical analogy rather than object evidence.

As a result, exact centuries should be attached to individual bowls only when the edition explains the basis.

2.5 Language and script groups

Modern working category	What it usually means	Main cautions
Jewish Babylonian Aramaic	Aramaic language normally written in Jewish square script	Script and Jewish textual material strongly suggest Jewish scribal environments, but do not by themselves identify every client or practitioner
Mandaic	Mandaic language and/or Mandaic script	A Mandaic-script object need not preserve only distinctively Mandaean content; classifications based on old copies require rechecking
Syriac	Syriac language or script, in several graphic forms	Christian names and formulae occur, but mixed repertoires and copied material complicate confessional assignment
Pahlavi	Middle Persian language or Pahlavi script	Smaller and less uniformly published corpus; it should not be folded into “Aramaic bowls” without qualification
Pseudo-script	Invented, imitative, or non-lexical signs arranged as writing	Not necessarily fraud or illiteracy; may exploit the visual prestige and supernatural legibility of writing

Recent work gives direct evidence for transmission across these categories. Simcha Gross and Michele Scarlassara's 2025 publication of Syriac bowl B9002 identifies a near-verbatim Mandaic incantation in a Syriac-script object, aided by multispectral imaging ([article DOI](#)). Ohad Abudraham's 2026 article re-edits several bowls while publishing a new National Library of Israel object and emphasizes the fusion of Jewish and Mandaic materials ([open-access article](#)). Such cases make “cross-confessional” transmission an object-level fact rather than only a general theory.

3. Origins and textual reservoirs of the incantations

The question “Where do bowl incantations come from?” needs to be divided into at least three questions: where the **bowl-as-ritual-object** developed, where its **reusable formulae and stories** came from, and where the **individual composition for a named household** was made. The answers are not identical. A cheap ceramic vessel could be a specifically Mesopotamian ritual medium even when the words written on it included biblical verses, legal formulae, translated Mandaic material, Iranian names, or stories with a much longer history.

3.1 The origin of the bowl practice

No surviving source narrates the invention of the practice, and the apparent suddenness of the archaeological record may be partly a problem of preservation. Gideon Bohak has asked whether comparable incantations were previously spoken or written on perishable materials. Metal amulets, gems, lead rolls, parchment, ostraca, skulls, and manuals show that late antique ritual writing already moved across media. What is distinctive is the large-scale Mesopotamian choice of ordinary bowls, frequently written in spirals and installed in houses. Erica Hunter's archaeological work and Waller's analysis of written performativity both make the local material setting indispensable: a bowl returned specialized writing to the gestural world of a household vessel, then changed that vessel's use through inscription and deposition.

Older Mesopotamian ritual traditions supplied a deep regional vocabulary of demons, witchcraft, binding, protection, figurines, house ritual, and expert incantation. Similarity alone, however, does not demonstrate a continuous line from cuneiform exorcistic series to a sixth-century Aramaic bowl. Languages, institutions, media, and textual forms changed over many centuries. Claims of descent are strongest when a distinctive narrative sequence, technical expression, ritual action, or demonological cluster can be traced through intermediate evidence; a general shared concern with hostile spirits is only regional background.

3.2 Local composition and professional repertoires

Most of an individual bowl is best understood as a local composition assembled for a concrete problem. The scribe or practitioner inserts a client's name, matronymic, spouse, children, house, property, adversary, symptoms, or feared being into a working repertoire. Formula families, repeated hands, shared layouts, and recurrent errors show that some practitioners copied exemplars or worked from memorized sequences. Yet variation is pervasive: passages are expanded, shortened, recombined, translated, and redirected. "Local" therefore does not mean improvised from nothing. It means that circulating materials acquired their operative form in a particular commission, workshop, household, and social network.

Legal and administrative speech was one such local reservoir. Bowls bind, seal, ban, excommunicate, adjure, or divorce harmful beings. Avigail Manekin-Bamberger's work demonstrates that divorce, oath, vow, and excommunication language could be repurposed as supernatural acts. The evidentiary claim should remain proportional: a technical resemblance can show familiarity with authoritative legal forms without proving that a rabbinic court wrote the bowl or that a particular written legal handbook was copied.

3.3 Biblical and liturgical material

Biblical language is prominent but not universal, and even in Jewish bowls it is usually one component of a larger incantation. Common materials include the Shema, the priestly blessing, psalms, Zechariah 3:2, Numbers 23:23, and language from Exodus and other protective or triumphal passages. Daniel James Waller's *The Bible in the Bowls* catalogues identifiable biblical quotations in published JBA bowls through November 2022. Dorota Molin and Daniel Frim show why the evidence matters beyond ritual history: these are the only direct epigraphic witnesses to Biblical Hebrew from late antique Babylonia, preserving spelling, pronunciation, reading, and memory practices before the medieval vocalized codices.

Waller's catalogue also prevents an important exaggeration. Biblical content does not make a whole incantation "biblical." A verse may supply one authoritative clause inside a text otherwise composed of adjurations, legal metaphors, client names, magical names, drawings, and locally transmitted formulae. Quotations range from close textual reproduction to abbreviation, conflation, Aramaic interference, and remembered wording. Some language may have reached a bowl through prayer or another magical text rather than direct consultation of a biblical manuscript. The safest vocabulary therefore distinguishes **quotation**, **adaptation**, **allusion**, and **formula that also occurs in scripture**.

Liturgy is related but not reducible to Bible. The Shema and other prayer language could circulate through communal recitation, household memory, written liturgical forms, or magical exemplars. Dan Levene's work on liturgical material asks how recognizable prayer was repositioned inside a new ritual argument. Here again, verbal identity, sequence, and distinctive variants matter more than a general resemblance.

3.4 Jewish literary, rabbinic, and magical traditions

The bowls share demons, rabbis, biblical interpretations, legal concepts, stories, and ritual assumptions with the Bavli and with other Jewish magical evidence. Named figures such as Ḥanina ben Dosa and Joshua ben Peraḥiah can authorize narratives of conquest over demons. Moses appears as lawgiver, master of divine names, and source of esoteric authority. Naveh and Shaked's comparative editions, Bohak's historical synthesis, Harari's study of early Jewish magic, and Mokhtarian's bowl-Talmud comparisons show a mobile repertoire that crossed amulets, manuals, liturgy, narrative, and rabbinic learning.

This does not make the Bavli the master source for the bowls. The Babylonian Talmud is itself composite and was transmitted and redacted over time. Exact dependence requires more than a shared demon or legal term: one should look for unusual wording, the same narrative order, a distinctive error, or a cluster of correspondences that is unlikely to arise from the common environment. In many cases, "shared Babylonian repertoire" is a more accurate conclusion than "the bowl quotes the Talmud."

3.5 Mandaic, Syriac, Iranian, and wider late antique sources

Mandaic and Syriac bowls have their own formula families, linguistic histories, named powers, and ritual logics. They must not be treated only as parallels to Jewish material. At the same time, close parallels demonstrate translation and borrowing across scripts. Gross and Scarlassara's B9002 is especially valuable because multispectral imaging revealed a Syriac-script bowl carrying a near-verbatim Mandaic incantation. Such a case permits a specific claim about textual movement; the mere presence of a shared angelic name would not.

Iranian influence appears in personal names, administrative and legal vocabulary, cosmology, geography, demons, and divine or astral beings. The bowls emerged in an Iranian empire, so these features are not exotic intrusions into an otherwise sealed Aramaic world. Nor does an Iranian name prove that its bearer was Zoroastrian. The same caution applies to Greek, Egyptian, or broader late antique magical names and signs: some belonged to widely circulating professional repertoires whose users did not adopt the theology of every name they invoked.

3.6 A source-critical model

For each passage, the review therefore asks five increasingly demanding questions:

1. **Identification:** Is the wording recognizably connected to another text or only thematically similar?
2. **Direction:** Can the source be earlier than the bowl, or might both depend on a third repertoire?
3. **Route:** Was the material likely copied, remembered, translated, heard in ritual, or borrowed through another magical object?
4. **Transformation:** What did the bowl add, omit, reorder, personalize, or materially reframe?
5. **Function:** What authority did the borrowed material claim in this specific incantation?

This model makes "origin" a history of transmission and recomposition rather than a search for one parent tradition. The most typical bowl is locally made and textually plural: its immediate composition belongs to a late antique Mesopotamian practitioner, while its components may reach into scripture, prayer, law, story, Iranian imperial culture, neighboring Aramaic traditions, older Mesopotamian ritual, and the wider technologies of ancient magic.

4. Chronological history of scholarship, 1853-2026

4.1 Discovery and decipherment, 1853-1912

Thomas Ellis's 1853 publication of bowls acquired by Austen Henry Layard is conventionally treated as the beginning of JBA bowl scholarship. Nineteenth-century work by Michel Nicolas Schwab, Joseph Halévy, Henry Hyvernât, Henri Pognon, and others tried to identify scripts, languages, divine names, demons, and analogues in rabbinic or biblical literature. Mark Lidzbarski and James A. Montgomery's near contemporaries improved Mandaic and Aramaic decipherment; J. A. Myhrman's 1909 edition added material from the Hilprecht collection.

This period established three habits that still require caution:

- treating badly provenanced acquisitions as though their findspots were certain;
- "correcting" nonstandard language toward classical or literary Aramaic;
- using assumed communal identity to solve ambiguous readings.

Its achievement was nonetheless fundamental: scholars recognized a coherent late antique ritual technology and began developing the dialect knowledge needed to read it.

4.2 Montgomery and the Nippur foundation, 1913

James A. Montgomery's *Aramaic Incantation Texts from Nippur* (1913) published forty bowls and one inscribed skull, with drawings or plates, glossary, grammatical discussion, religious parallels, and archaeological framing. It remains the foundational point of reference; Cambridge's modern edition describes its forty bowl texts and forty-one illustrations ([book record](#)).

Montgomery's strengths were breadth and comparativism. His weaknesses are those of an early edition: selective publication, hand copies rather than modern imaging, readings made before the dialects were well understood, and interpretive categories shaped by older “magic versus religion” models. Modern researchers must cite his numbering because it anchors the field, but should not assume that his transcription is the last word.

CBS/B 2941, Montgomery no. 38, illustrates the continuing value and limitation of his numbering: it can be traced across later scholarship as Yamauchi's Mandaic Text 23, but its individual readings still require comparison with the object image and subsequent Mandaic work.

4.3 Expansion, classification, and compilation, 1930s-1970s

Cyrus H. Gordon published numerous bowls from collections in Europe, North America, and the Middle East from the 1930s onward. Other important contributions include J. Obermann, W. H. Rossell's 1953 dissertation, Edwin M. Yamauchi, William S. McCullough, and Stephen A. Kaufman. The period greatly enlarged the known corpus but also multiplied sigla and uneven hand copies.

Three books became landmarks:

- **Edwin M. Yamauchi, *Mandaic Incantation Texts* (1967).** This organized an early Mandaic corpus, grammar, and glossary. Its Text 23 reprints or re-edits Montgomery 38 and provides a useful example of how one object moves through successive corpus systems ([contents preview](#)).
- **William S. McCullough, *Jewish and Mandaean Incantation Bowls in the Royal Ontario Museum* (1967).** This remains a major collection publication ([JSTOR record](#)).
- **Charles D. Isbell, *Corpus of the Aramaic Incantation Bowls* (1975).** Useful as a concordance compilation of then-published material, but no longer reliable as a sole text edition because it inherits and sometimes adds earlier errors.

The period's prevailing questions were philological and comparative: Which dialect is present? Which demonological or angelological tradition appears? How does a formula compare with the Talmud, Mandaism, or older Mesopotamian religion? Social and archaeological questions were usually secondary.

4.4 Reliable corpora and comparative philology, 1980s-2005

Joseph Naveh and Shaul Shaked's *Amulets and Magic Bowls* (1985; second edition 1987) and *Magic Spells and Formulae* (1993) set a higher standard for text edition, translation, and comparative analysis. Their work demonstrated the importance of formula families, manuscript parallels, and the circulation of Jewish magical traditions across object types.

The period also produced:

- Tapani Harviainen's philological studies and publications;
- Christa Müller-Kessler's work on JBA, Mandaic, Syriac, and the Hilprecht collection;
- T. M. C. Greenfield, Markham J. Geller, Shaul Shaked, and others on individual texts and traditions;
- Heikki Juusola's *Linguistic Peculiarities in the Aramaic Magic Bowl Texts* (1999), a major dialect study ([publisher record](#));
- J. B. Segal's *Catalogue of the Aramaic and Mandaic Incantation Bowls in the British Museum* (2000), a central museum corpus ([catalogue record](#));
- Dan Levene's *A Corpus of Magic Bowls* (2003), one of the core JBA editions ([UCL⁸ record](#));
- Müller-Kessler's 2005 re-edition of the Hilprecht collection.

These works remain the backbone of text-based research. They also revealed how many older “lexical oddities” were misreadings, how frequently one bowl illuminates another, and why photographs must accompany editions.

4.5 Social, literary, and material turns, 2006-2015

The next decade integrated bowls into broader histories of ancient magic and late antique religion. Gideon Bohak's *Ancient Jewish Magic* (2008) and Yuval Harari's later *Jewish Magic before the Rise of Kabbalah* (English 2017) located bowls within long Jewish magical traditions without treating rabbinic prohibition as an adequate description of lived practice. Michael G. Morony emphasized Sasanian Iraqi society and the religiously plural environment; his “Magic and Society in Late Sasanian Iraq” and “Religion and the Aramaic Incantation Bowls” remain basic social-historical statements ([article record](#)).

The bowls also became evidence for literary creativity. Scholars studied *historiolae*, first-person narratives, aggressive curses, formula migration, and named rabbinic wonder-workers. Jason Sion Mokhtarian's work compared bowls with the Babylonian Talmud while resisting a simple derivation in either direction; *Rabbis, Sorcerers, Kings, and Priests* (2015) is a major synthesis ([Oxford chapter record](#)).

Two corpus milestones appeared:

- Shaul Shaked, James Nathan Ford, and Siam Bhayro, *Aramaic Bowl Spells*, vol. 1 (2013), edited sixty-four Schøyen JBA bowls and identified major spell families, including magical divorce and narratives about Ḥanina ben Dosa and Joshua ben Peraḥiah ([Brill record](#)).
- Marco Moriggi, *A Corpus of Syriac Incantation Bowls* (2014), made the Syriac material available for systematic comparison ([Brill front matter](#)).

At the same time, the divide between “popular magic” and “rabbinic religion” began to erode. Legal language, liturgical material, biblical quotations, and technical learning show that at least some practitioners inhabited literate environments adjacent to other Jewish textual cultures. This does not make all bowl scribes rabbis; it makes the corpus heterogeneous.

⁸ University College London.

4.6 Museum corpora, digital methods, gender, and provenance, 2016-2022

Publication accelerated and became more systematic:

- Siam Bhayro, James Nathan Ford, Dan Levene, and Ortal-Paz Saar, *Aramaic Magic Bowls in the Vorderasiatisches Museum in Berlin* (2018), catalogued 177 items and edited selected examples.
- James Nathan Ford and Matthew Morgenstern, *Aramaic Incantation Bowls in Museum Collections*, vol. 1 (2019/2020), treated the Hilprecht collection in Jena and included inscribed, Pahlavi, and pseudo-script material ([Brill record](#)).
- Shaked, Ford, and Bhayro, *Aramaic Bowl Spells*, vol. 2 (2022), added fifty-five Schøyen bowls and related seals or signet rings ([Brill front matter](#)).

Digital projects began to address scale. The Virtual Magic Bowl Archive, established by Dan Levene and now hosted at Exeter, provides photographs and resources connected especially to the roughly 650 Schøyen texts ([VMBA⁹ project page](#)). The EJCM project situates bowls within a structured, comparative corpus of Jewish classical magic ([EJCM](#)). Machine-learning work on scripts and handwriting remains exploratory, but it has made reproducible image sets and explicit classification criteria more urgent.

Gender and household history became central. Client naming, matronymics, reproductive protection, kin relations, and first-person grammar offer abundant evidence, but the identity of the person speaking in a spell cannot automatically be equated with the identity of the person who wrote the object. Dorit Kedar's 2019 dissertation, *Who Wrote the Incantation Bowls?*, argues for female authors or scribes in a group of cases ([repository record](#)); later work by Ortal-Paz Saar and Avigail Manekin-Bamberger urges stricter separation among author, textual voice, copyist, producer, client, and beneficiary. Saar's 2024 survey is a particularly clear methodological statement ([open-access article](#)).

Research on biblical quotations also matured. Dorota Molin showed that the bowls are the only epigraphic witnesses to Biblical Hebrew from late antique Babylonia and can preserve reading traditions, oral transmission, and Aramaic interference ([open-access chapter](#)). Waller's *The Bible in the Bowls* (2022) catalogued every biblical quotation he could identify in published JBA bowls as of November 2022, turning a recurrent impression into an auditable dataset ([open-access book](#)).

Finally, provenance could no longer be treated as an external concern. The post-1990 market supplied large undocumented collections while looting removed find context from Iraq. The Schøyen controversy made the stakes unusually visible. Beginning in 1995-1996, University College London held 654 bowls from Martin Schøyen's private collection for research. Media and scholarly investigations questioned whether bowls of probable Iraqi origin had left Iraq unlawfully after the 1990 invasion of Kuwait; UCL convened a provenance inquiry in 2004. When the bowls were not promptly returned, the collection sued UCL in 2007. An out-of-court settlement returned the objects and UCL stated that no adverse claim to title had been made, but the inquiry report was not published. Neil Brodie reports that leaked findings considered post-1990 removal from Iraq probable; the Schøyen Collection rejects that account and maintains that the bowls came from a long-held Jordanian collection and were exported from Jordan under a 1988 license. The unresolved public record is the controversy: legal title, archaeological origin, export history, and scholarly ethics were repeatedly treated as though one answer settled all four ([UCL joint statement](#); [Brodie's documented reconstruction](#); [collection's position](#)).

⁹ Virtual Magic Bowl Archive, the University of Exeter digital resource for incantation-bowl images and research materials.

The episode changed responsible practice even without a final public adjudication of every bowl. Scholarship can edit unprovenanced material, but it should disclose acquisition claims, distinguish title from archaeological provenience, avoid laundering dealer geography into findspot, and recognize that authentication and publication can increase market value. It also explains why the two *Aramaic Bowl Spells* volumes are simultaneously indispensable philology and ethically incomplete object histories.

4.7 Consolidation and new directions, 2023-2026

The 2025 edited volume *Aramaic Incantation Bowls in Their Late Antique Jewish Contexts*, edited by Alexander W. Marcus and Jason Sion Mokhtarian, is the best current gateway to the JBA field. Its chapters cover the publication history, lexicon, matronymics, gender, motherhood, bodies, families, names, textual variation, liturgy, digital ontology, and Sasanian Jewish history. Waller's opening "State of the Art" includes a map and publication list through 2024 ([table of contents](#)).

The volume captures several current tendencies:

- **lexical revision:** Ford identifies new lexemes, new meanings, and "ghost words" created by old misreadings;
- **variation as evidence:** Marcus treats divergences as potentially meaningful transmission, not merely scribal incompetence;
- **families and naming:** Mokhtarian, Ilan, and Burberry use named people and relationships as social evidence;
- **ritual embodiment:** Saar, Eliassian, and Kiperwasser examine gender, motherhood, and bodies without assuming that prescriptive categories map directly onto clients;
- **structured data:** Walker argues for an ontology capable of relating texts, hands, people, formulae, images, objects, collections, and editions;
- **historical anchoring:** Bhayro brings the bowls into Sasanian Jewish history and emphasizes absolutely dated specimens.

Related work has sharpened the bowl-Talmud comparison. Simcha Gross and Avigail Manekin-Bamberger argue that Babylonian Jewish society in the bowls is internally diverse and that some scribes were close to learned legal and literary milieus, making "popular versus rabbinic" an inadequate binary ([JQR¹⁰ article record](#)). Shai Secunda's 2025 study treats the Talmud and bowls as participants in a wider Babylonian textual culture, emphasizing reworking and circulation rather than hunting only for exact quotation ([article record](#)).

The newest object publications reinforce hybridity and technical re-examination. Gross and Scarlassara's Syriac B9002, Abudraham's 2026 re-editions, and Rivett and Wilkinson's 2026 study of YHBYH and the Tetragrammaton all revisit inherited readings and presumed communal boundaries. The last study argues that YHBYH should be treated as an independent divine name in at least some bowl contexts, rather than automatically as a vocalized form of YHWH ([article DOI](#)). These studies show that the field is still generating basic philological discoveries, not merely applying new theories to a settled corpus.

¹⁰ Jewish Quarterly Review.

5. Principal editions and research infrastructure

5.1 Jewish Babylonian Aramaic

Work	Contribution	Present use
Montgomery 1913	Foundational Nippur corpus	Always check; re-collate where possible
Isbell 1975	Compilation of earlier published bowls	Concordance value; not a final edition
Naveh & Shaked 1987, 1993	Reliable editions and formula comparison	Core reference
Segal 2000	British Museum catalogue	Core museum corpus; readings sometimes superseded
Levene 2003	Major JBA corpus	Core reference
Müller-Kessler 2005	Hilprecht/Jena re-editions	Important, but compare with Ford-Morgenstern
Shaked, Ford & Bhayro 2013, 2022	119 Schøyen bowls plus related objects	Current high-level editions; provenance must still be recorded
Bhayro et al. 2018	Berlin collection, 177 catalogue entries	Essential museum and material reference
Ford & Morgenstern 2019/2020	Hilprecht museum corpus with high-quality documentation	Preferred current Jena reference
Waller 2022	Biblical quotations in published JBA bowls	Thematic catalogue, not a full bowl corpus
Marcus & Mokhtarian 2025, eds.	State of field and thematic synthesis	Current starting point

5.2 Mandaic

Work	Contribution	Present use
Pognon 1898	Khouabir Mandaic bowls	Foundational but requires modern rechecking
Montgomery 1913, nos. 38-40	Nippur Mandaic bowls	Includes CBS/B 2941
Yamauchi 1967	Corpus, grammar, glossary	Essential historical reference; readings should be checked against images and newer Mandaic scholarship
McCullough 1967	Royal Ontario Museum Jewish and Mandaean bowls	Major collection
Segal 2000	British Museum Aramaic and Mandaic bowls	Core collection
Müller-Kessler and Morgenstern, various	New editions, dialect, and textual parallels	Essential for correction and comparison
Ford & Abudraham and later individual studies	New Mandaic texts and re-editions	Rapidly developing layer
Abudraham 2026	New NLI bowl and three re-editions	Important recent bridge between Jewish and Mandaic repertoires

The Mandaic corpus is smaller in current working counts than JBA but is indispensable. It should not be used merely as a reservoir of parallels for Jewish texts; it has its own language history, ritual traditions, scribal conventions, and internal formula families.

5.3 Syriac

Work	Contribution	Present use
Montgomery 1913 and scattered early editions	Initial Syriac examples	Historical starting point
Geller, Teixidor, Harviainen, Müller-Kessler, others	Individual texts and linguistic analysis	Must be gathered across articles
Moriggi 2014	First modern systematic Syriac corpus	Primary reference
Ford & Morgenstern 2019/2020	Jena museum material	Important images and catalogue data
Gross & Scarlassara 2025	B9002, with multispectral imaging and Mandaic parallel	Model for cross-script and technical study

5.4 Pahlavi, pseudo-script, and images

These materials remain less comprehensively synthesized. Pahlavi bowls connect the corpus to Iranian language and religious history. Pseudo-script bowls show that the authority of writing could be visual even where no ordinary text can be read. Waller's "Curious Characters, Invented Scripts, and ... Charlatans?" rejects a blanket assumption that such bowls are simply incompetent frauds; their signs imitate, exaggerate, or strategically transform script (*Journal of Near Eastern Studies* 78 [2019]: 119-139). His related open-access article argues that bowl efficacy often inheres in writtenness itself ([Cambridge Core](#)).

Naama Vilozy's work on drawings - especially demons, bound figures, Lilith, and Ashmedai - has established images as operative components rather than decoration. Future cataloguing should therefore describe image placement, orientation, gestures, bindings, labels, and relation to text.

6. Interpretive synthesis: what the evidence presently supports

The chronological history above shows why the field's questions cannot be separated into isolated topics. Changes in editing altered what counted as a word; archaeology altered what counted as context; gender history altered who counted as an agent; and provenance research altered which historical claims an object can bear. Six connected propositions summarize the strongest present interpretations.

6.1 Ritual problems were translated into authoritative actions

Protection is the largest category, but it is not one simple function. Bowls address named demons and liliths, illness and bodily pain, sleep disturbance, pregnancy and infant survival, marriage and household conflict, property and livelihood, curses and witchcraft, legal success, separation, subordination, and retaliatory harm. One object may protect a person, spouse, children, house, animals, and possessions at once. "Apotropaic" and "aggressive" are not opposites when protection works by returning a curse or coercing its sender.

The recurring verbs reveal a ritual grammar. Harmful beings are bound, sealed, banned, excommunicated, adjured, or divorced. Avigail Manekin-Bamberger traced verbal parallels among bowl formulae, the Bavli, and surviving legal documents, showing that divorce, oath, vow, and excommunication language could turn socially recognized acts of separation into supernatural operations ([article record](#)). Her contribution is methodological as much as lexical: legal speech could circulate beyond formal institutions, so resemblance does not require a rabbinic court to have produced the object.

6.2 Authority was assembled from names, stories, scripture, and material form

Bowls invoke the God of Israel; Jesus or Christian powers in some Syriac texts; angels, demons, planets, and Iranian beings; biblical ancestors; rabbis; and legendary ritual experts. Practitioners combine and transform names because efficacy could be claimed through identity, sound, spelling, visual pattern, narrative precedent, or accumulation. Moses is important as lawgiver and master of authorized divine speech. Siam Bhayro's study of Moses in the bowls shows how practitioners recruit Mosaic legacy without implying that the corpus as a whole claims Mosaic authorship ([open PDF](#)).

The distinction between **YHWH** and **YHBYH** illustrates why such names must not be normalized too quickly. YHWH is the four-consonant Tetragrammaton, the biblical name conventionally avoided in Jewish pronunciation. YHBYH is a different five-consonant written sequence: *yod-he-bet-yod-he*. Montgomery connected it with Greek spellings such as *labē* and proposed that it encoded a pronunciation of YHWH; Naveh and Shaked judged that suggestion attractive but unproved and treated it as another magical divine name. Pilar B. Rivett and Robert J. Wilkinson's 2026 survey widens the evidence base and shows contexts in which YHBYH behaves independently rather than as a mere spelling of YHWH ([article DOI](#)). Their argument does **not** establish one historical pronunciation of the Tetragrammaton. It establishes a safer editorial rule: transcribe YHBYH as written, do not silently replace or translate it as YHWH, and decide from each syntax and parallel whether the scribe treated it as an independent theonym.

Biblical and liturgical passages contribute another kind of authority, while the vessel, spiral, image, and deposition make that authority materially durable. Waller's biblical catalogue, Molin's work on reading traditions, Levene's work on liturgy, and Viložny's analysis of images collectively show that no single layer - word, voice, picture, or object - should be assumed to carry the whole ritual act.

6.3 Production ranged from copying to recomposition, and from speech to visible writing

Repeated hands, formula clusters, shared errors, and near-identical layouts support practitioners, exemplars, workshops, or local networks. Yet "school" requires several converging features: a formula can travel between hands, and one hand can use several repertoires. Alexander Marcus treats variation as evidence for transmission and purposeful adaptation, while James Nathan Ford's lexical corrections show how supposed scribal oddities can instead be dialect, phonetic spelling, graphic convention, or an editor's ghost word.

Charles Häberl emphasized oral performance and the possibility that some performative utterances record spoken acts. Waller shifted attention to the way spiral layout, pseudo-script, drawing, durable ink, and deposition make writing performative in itself ([open-access article](#)). These positions define a continuum rather than a forced choice: remembered formula to inscription; written exemplar to copied bowl; adapted template to personalized object; spoken act joined to writing; or visually authoritative signs with little ordinary lexical content.

6.4 Households join gender, kinship, health, and economy

Named clients and kin make the corpus unusually rich for microhistory. The bowls record matronymics, marriages, children, multi-generational households, adversaries, houses, animals, goods, and livelihoods. They do not observe modern boundaries among medical, psychological, legal, social, and demonic causation: pain, nightmares, reproductive danger, paralysis, fever, conflict, and supernatural attack can occupy one ritual frame.

Women occur frequently as clients and beneficiaries, especially in material concerning marriage, fertility, pregnancy, childbirth, infants, and household conflict. Dorit Kedar argues that a set of first-person feminine texts reveals female authors or scribes. Ortal-Paz Saar's 2024 review and Manekin-Bamberger's 2025 "Magic Formulae and Women's History" respond by separating author, textual voice, copyist, producer, commissioner, client, and beneficiary, and by asking what recurrent formulae reveal about gendered fears and agency ([article record](#)). This exchange advanced the field because it converted a binary question - "Were women scribes?" - into roles and claims that can be tested bowl by bowl.

Prosopography requires the same discipline. One person can occur on several bowls, spelling varies, and catalogue sigla can disguise duplicates. A social history built only from names will overcount; it needs images, hands, family links, provenance, and separate uncertainty values.

6.5 The bowls and the Bavli overlap without becoming the same archive

Bavli is the conventional short name for the Babylonian Talmud, a multi-generational rabbinic compilation of legal discussion, interpretation, and narrative shaped in late antique Babylonia and transmitted through later redaction. It is niche terminology because specialists often use it as though it named a single contemporary book. For comparison with the bowls, three cautions follow: the Bavli is layered rather than a dated snapshot; it speaks through rabbinic literary conventions rather than household commissions; and a parallel may reflect a shared oral, legal, ritual, or narrative environment rather than direct copying.

The scholarship moved from an opposition between rabbinic religion and "popular magic," through attempts to identify bowl scribes as rabbis, to a heterogeneous overlap model. Simcha Gross and Avigail Manekin-Bamberger identify some bowl scribes with unusual proximity to learned legal and rabbinic milieus. Shai Secunda emphasizes circulation and reworking across Babylonian textual culture. Jason Sion Mokhtarian compares demons, kings, priests, rabbis, and stories without collapsing genre. Together their work supports uneven contact: some practitioners display specialist learning, others do not; a title such as "rabbi" can belong to a client; and exact dependence remains possible only where wording and structure warrant it.

6.6 Religious plurality and provenance are interpretive variables

Shared names, formulae, stories, and graphic devices show contact among Jewish, Mandaean, Christian, Iranian, and other traditions. "Syncretism" is too blunt if it replaces the questions that matter: Was a passage translated across scripts? Did one hand serve clients from more than one group? Was a powerful name borrowed without its theology? Did a formula belong to a regional professional repertoire? Recent parallel texts make these questions testable.

Unprovenanced bowls may preserve ancient texts, but they cannot support household or depositional history with the authority of an excavated object. Responsible scholarship records ownership before and after 1970 and 1990, export and acquisition evidence, dealer claims versus excavated findspots, physical examination, pre-restoration images, duplicate publication, and authenticity concerns. The market also selects for attractive, legible, figurative, and apparently Jewish objects. Provenance is therefore not a detachable ethics paragraph; it changes sampling, dating, geography, interpretation, and the confidence assigned to every historical conclusion.

7. Live scholarly disputes

Question	Strongest positions	Present assessment
Were bowls transcriptions of spoken rituals?	Häberl emphasizes oral performance; Waller emphasizes written performativity	Both modes likely occurred; no universal ritual can be reconstructed
Were practitioners outside rabbinic culture?	Older “popular versus rabbinic” model; newer overlap model	Corpus is heterogeneous; some learned proximity, no basis for making all scribes rabbis
Can script identify religion?	Traditional catalogue practice often assumes yes	Script is evidence, not proof of producer or client identity
Were women bowl scribes?	Kedar and some readings argue yes; Saar and Manekin-Bamberger urge role separation	Possible in individual cases; not established for the corpus as a class
Are unusual forms scribal mistakes?	Older correction-heavy editions; newer variation studies	Decide case by case after dialect, parallels, image, and hand are checked
Are pseudo-scripts fraudulent?	“Illiterate charlatan” explanation; visual/material efficacy explanation	Multiple functions likely; fraud cannot be inferred merely from non-lexical signs
Did bowls trap demons physically?	Popular containment model; broader apotropaic-material model	Some text and placement support containment; it is not a universal explanation
Do bowl parallels prove dependence on the Bavli?	Direct borrowing model; shared ecology model	Exact dependence is sometimes possible, but shared repertoire is the safer default
Is YHBYH a spelling or pronunciation of YHWH?	Montgomery linked it to Greek vocalizations; later scholars treat it as another or independent divine name	Preserve YHBYH as written; determine its force from each occurrence rather than normalizing it to YHWH
Did the 2007 Schøyen settlement resolve provenance?	The collection emphasizes legal title and a Jordanian export history; critical accounts emphasize probable Iraqi origin and the unpublished UCL inquiry	No: title, archaeological provenience, export history, and research ethics remain distinct questions

8. Research gaps with the highest payoff

1. **Publication of excavated museum reserves.** Penn's largely unpublished Nippur holdings could radically improve typology, household context, and sampling bias.
2. **Mandaic and Syriac parity.** JBA now has stronger corpora and thematic tools; comparative conclusions require similar object-level infrastructure for Mandaic, Syriac, Pahlavi, and pseudo-script bowls.
3. **Stable identifiers and concordances.** One object may have excavation, museum, publication, and dealer numbers. A crosswalk is foundational.
4. **Palaeographic chronology.** Handwriting groups need anchoring to dated or excavated specimens, with transparent image criteria.
5. **Material science.** Petrography, clay sourcing, ink chemistry, reflectance transformation imaging, and multispectral imaging can distinguish workshops, recover readings, and test authenticity.
6. **Household archaeology.** Depositional position, associated architecture, paired bowls, and reuse need spatial publication.
7. **Formula genealogy.** Digital alignment can show whether shared passages reflect exemplars, memory, local workshop practice, or cross-language translation.
8. **Gender across language groups.** Most synthesis centers JBA; Mandaic and Syriac evidence needs equal analysis and stricter role annotation.
9. **Economic history of practice.** Prices, access, professionalization, repeat clients, and workshop organization remain mostly inferential.
10. **Ethical publication standards.** The field needs consistent provenance statements, image histories, and treatment of post-conflict acquisitions.
11. **Digital preservation.** Projects need downloadable, versioned data with persistent identifiers so that a website's disappearance does not erase scholarly infrastructure.

9. Reproducible plan for continuing the review

Phase 1 - Establish the bibliography and rules (one week)

1. Create a Zotero collection with folders for editions, archaeology, JBA, Mandaic, Syriac, Pahlavi/pseudo-script, images, social history, language, Bible/liturgy, gender, medicine, digital methods, and provenance.
2. Adopt a fixed style and attach PDFs only where lawful access permits.
3. Seed the collection with Waller's 2025 publication list, Waller 2022 bibliography, the major corpora in section 5, Moriggi 2014, and the 2025 edited volume.

- 4. Record an **access status** for every item: full text read, relevant chapter read, abstract only, bibliographic only, or requested.
- 5. Write explicit inclusion rules: scholarly primary edition, object catalogue, excavation report, peer-reviewed analysis, substantial dissertation, or authoritative project. Keep popular and commercial material in a separate reception/provenance folder.

Immediate acquisition priority: obtain the complete 2025 Marcus-Mokhtarian volume through a research library or interlibrary loan. Its state-of-the-art bibliography through 2024 is the nearest available control list.

Phase 2 - Create an object/source ledger (one to two weeks, then ongoing)

Use one row per physical object, not one row per publication. Minimum fields:

Field group	Fields
Identity	canonical object ID; all aliases; museum; shelfmark; excavation number
Provenance	excavated/dealer/unknown; site; locus; stratum; acquisition history; confidence grade
Physical	dimensions; fabric; ink; condition; orientation; lines; interior/exterior; paired object
Text	language; script; direction; edition; translation; opening words; closing words
People	client; mother; spouse; children; adversary; practitioner; titles; uncertainty
Ritual	goal; threat; verbs of action; divine names; angels; demons; legal formulae; narrative
Intertexts	Bible; liturgy; Bavli; Mandaic; Syriac; Iranian; older Mesopotamian parallels
Visual	figure type; labels; circles; grids; signs; pseudo-script; image link and rights
Scholarship	first edition; re-editions; corrections; hand group; formula family; bibliography
Ethics/QA	provenance flag; authenticity concern; photo checked; collation status; reviewer

Maintain separate certainty values for reading, translation, identity, date, provenance, hand, and religious attribution. A single generic “confidence” field hides too much.

Phase 3 - Systematic discovery and citation chaining (two to four weeks)

Search the following, saving exact search strings and dates:

- RAMBI, JSTOR, ATLA Religion Database, Index Islamicus, L'Année philologique, ProQuest Dissertations, WorldCat, Google Scholar, Crossref, OpenAlex, and institutional repositories;

- journal archives for *Aramaic Studies*, *Journal of Semitic Studies*, *Bulletin of SOAS*, *Jewish Quarterly Review*, *Journal of the American Oriental Society*, *Journal of Near Eastern Studies*, *Iraq*, *Orientalia*, *Le Muséon*, *Semitica*, *ARAM*, *Archiv für Orientforschung*, and *Altorientalische Forschungen*;
- multilingual queries using the terms listed in section 1.3;
- object-number queries for CBS/B, BM, VA, MS, ROM¹¹, and Hilprecht sigla;
- opening-formula and rare-name searches when object numbers fail.

For every core work, perform:

1. backward chaining through its bibliography;
2. forward chaining through “cited by” indexes;
3. author searching for later corrections or related editions;
4. object-siglum searching to detect re-editions;
5. formula searching to find unnamed parallels.

Prioritize Montgomery 1913, Segal 2000, Levene 2003, Moriggi 2014, both *Aramaic Bowl Spells* volumes, Berlin 2018, Ford-Morgenstern, Waller 2022, and Marcus-Mokhtarian 2025.

Phase 4 - Reading sequence (six to eight weeks)

Tier 1: orientation

- Waller's 2025 “State of the Art”;
- Bohak 2008 and Harari 2017 for synthetic context;
- Morony 2003/2007 for Sasanian society;
- Hunter for archaeology;
- Gross-Manekin-Bamberger 2022 for social heterogeneity.

Tier 2: primary corpora

- Montgomery; Naveh-Shaked; Segal; Levene;
- Moriggi for Syriac;
- Yamauchi plus later Mandaic corrections;
- Berlin, Jena, and *Aramaic Bowl Spells* volumes.

Tier 3: thematic clusters

- Bible and Hebrew: Molin, Frim, Waller;
- Talmud and learned culture: Mokhtarian, Manekin-Bamberger, Secunda, Shaked;
- gender and family: Kedar, Saar, Ilan, Eliassian, Manekin-Bamberger;
- images and writtenness: Viložny, Waller, Häberl;

¹¹ Royal Ontario Museum.

- linguistics: Juusola, Ford, Morgenstern, Müller-Kessler;
- provenance: Brodie and related cultural-property research.

Tier 4: object-led work

Read every publication attached to the specific bowl, hand, formula, or client under study. Object-level questions should override generic literature-review order.

Phase 5 - Verification and expert contact (ongoing)

- Request high-resolution images and full catalogue records from Penn, the British Museum, Berlin, Jena, the Royal Ontario Museum, and other holders.
- Use the [Virtual Magic Bowl Archive](#) and [EJCM](#), but record access date and data version.
- Contact relevant specialists only with bounded questions and an image, transcription, previous readings, and exact uncertainty. Likely areas of expertise include JBA philology, Mandaic, Syriac, palaeography, biblical text, images, gender, and provenance.
- Ask museums for excavation and acquisition documentation separately; catalogue departments may not hold archaeological records.
- Never treat an expert's informal suggestion as a published reading without permission and attribution.

Phase 6 - Maintain and publish the review (quarterly)

1. Freeze a dated bibliography and ledger export every quarter in CSV, BibTeX, and Markdown.
2. Keep a change log: new object, new edition, corrected reading, changed provenance, duplicate merged, or attribution revised.
3. Run duplicate checks by object aliases and opening words.
4. Sample-audit at least 10% of rows against images and cited editions.
5. Preserve negative findings such as “museum image unavailable” or “later citation only repeats Montgomery.”
6. Produce annual narrative updates organized around changes in evidence, not just newly published titles.
7. Mark every modern adaptation derived from a bowl with its ancient base text, modern interventions, and date.

Suggested twelve-week target

Weeks	Deliverable
1-2	Zotero library, inclusion rules, search log, first 100 core records
3-5	Pilot object ledger spanning excavated and unprovenanced JBA, Mandaic, Syriac, Pahlavi, and pseudo-script examples
6-8	Thematic reading memos on ritual, intertexts, gender, and cross-confessional transmission
9-10	Pilot full collation of CBS/B 2941 as one Mandaic test case, plus a matched JBA test case
11	Provenance and identifier audit
12	Revised review, annotated bibliography, and public-facing source statement

10. Selected core bibliography

This list is intentionally selective: it identifies works that establish corpora, methods, or major debates. Waller's 2025 bibliography should be used as the comprehensive publication control through 2024.

Foundational editions and collections

- Montgomery, James A. *Aramaic Incantation Texts from Nippur*. Philadelphia, 1913.
- Pognon, Henri. *Inscriptions mandaites des coupes de Khouabir*. Paris, 1898.
- Myhrman, J. A. "An Aramaic Incantation Text." 1909.
- Gordon, Cyrus H. Multiple bowl editions, 1934-1984.
- Yamauchi, Edwin M. *Mandaic Incantation Texts*. American Oriental Series 49. 1967.
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Conclusion

Incantation bowls are best understood neither as a fossilized folk custom nor as illustrations of one religious tradition. They are a large, internally varied archive of domestic ritual writing produced in late antique Mesopotamia. Their texts combine local need with portable professional repertoires; their scripts and divine names cross boundaries more readily than older communal typologies allowed; and their physical placement makes the household an essential unit of interpretation.

The field's future lies in joining four forms of evidence that have too often been separated: exact philology, high-quality images and material study, archaeological/provenance history, and structured comparison across objects. The same rule should govern every modern adaptation derived from a bowl: identify the object, verify the image and latest edition, separate ancient text from modern intervention, and preserve the editorial trail.